

ISSUE #1

BACKYARD ROCKETS



THE OXIDIZER GAP

MOJAVE DESERT:
NEAR FUTURE.

HOW'S THE WELD
LOOK, ARV?





THE WELD
LOOKS CONFIDENT.
THE FRACTURE
DISAGREES.

WHAT WOULD
MAKE YOU TRUST THE
WHOLE ASSEMBLY, NOT
JUST THE WELD?



A FAILURE WE
CAN PREDICT, CONTAIN,
AND WALK AWAY
FROM.



SO TRUST MEANS
KNOWING HOW IT
BREAKS?



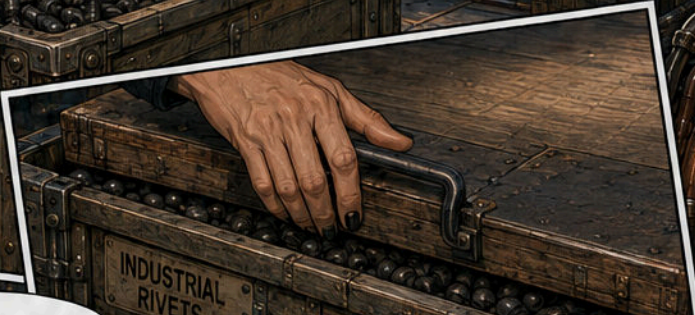
TRUST MEANS IT
DOES NOT GET TO
SURPRISE MY CREW.



I AM
SORTING WHAT KEEPS
THE NEXT LAUNCH ALIVE
FROM WHAT ONLY
SLOWS US DOWN.

INDUSTRIAL
RIVETS

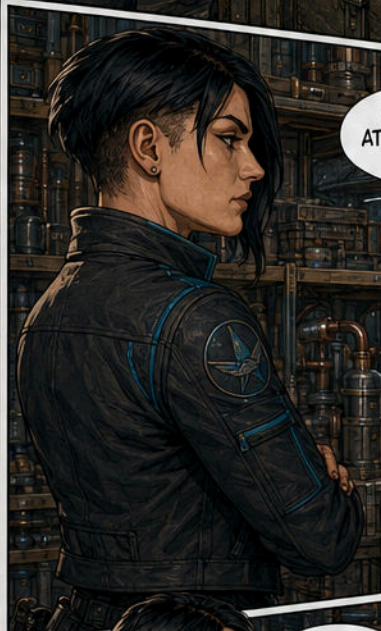
INDUSTRIAL
RIVETS



DO YOU EVER LOOK
AT A PART AND SEE WHAT
IT USED TO BE?



I SEE WHAT IT
SURVIVED, THEN I ASK
WHAT IT CAN BECOME.



I LIKE
KNOWING WHERE
THINGS CAME
FROM.



YOU KEEP THE
BIOGRAPHY. I WILL
MAKE SURE IT GETS
ANOTHER CHAPTER.



SAME HOBBY.
DIFFERENT
ENDING.

TELL THE BOARD
WE HAVE VISUAL
CONFIRMATION ON
THE LEAD TANKER.



WHAT IS THE PART
YOU ARE NOT SAYING
OUT LOUD?



THE MARGIN IS
SMALLER THAN I
PROMISED THE TEAM.

SMALLER THAN YOU
WANT OR SMALLER
THAN YOU CAN
DEFEND?



TODAY THEY ARE
THE SAME QUESTION.
I DO NOT LAUNCH ON
HOPE ALONE.

BEFORE TETHERWELL, UNCOORDINATED
PUMPING BROUGHT THE BASIN WITHIN
MONTHS OF COLLAPSE. ONE SHARED NETWORK
GAVE THE DESERT TIME TO SURVIVE.



TETHERWELL

EVERY DROP, ACCOUNTED FOR.



EASY, MILO.
ONE MORE TURN AND
THE BRACKET BECOMES
THE FAILURE.

IF THIS WORKS,
WHERE DO YOU THINK
THE PAYLOAD IS WHEN
WE GO TO SLEEP?

CROSSING THE DARK
WHILE WE SLEEP, GIVING
ANOTHER SETTLEMENT A
TETHERWELL SIGNAL THEY
CONTROL.

THAT WAS
ALMOST
POETIC.

ORBITAL MECHANICS
CAN BE POETIC.
DO NOT TELL ANYONE
I SAID THAT.



WE IGNITE NOW OR
THE WINDOW CLOSES.
MILO, STAY WITH ME
ON THE FEED
PRESSURE.

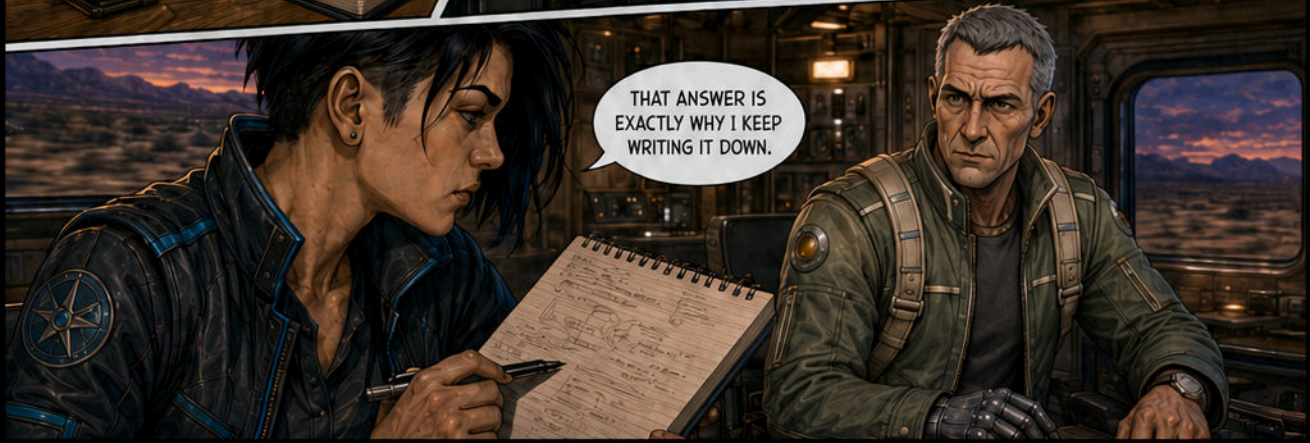


WHAT DID YOU
THINK YOU WERE GOING
TO BE DOING AT
MY AGE?

DESIGNING
SOMETHING SAFER,
WITH A BUDGET LARGE
ENOUGH TO HIDE THE
COMPROMISES.

BETTER?

CLEANER, YES.
BETTER? NOT UNTIL
I FOUND THIS CREW.





WILL THAT UNEVEN
BEAD OPEN UP WHEN THE AIR
THINS, OR AM I WORRYING AT
THE WRONG PART?



WHAT DO YOU
MISS WHEN WE LAST
PUT TOO LONG?



THE HORIZON
CHANGING. AND ALL OF
YOU COMPLAINING IN A
NEW LOCATION.

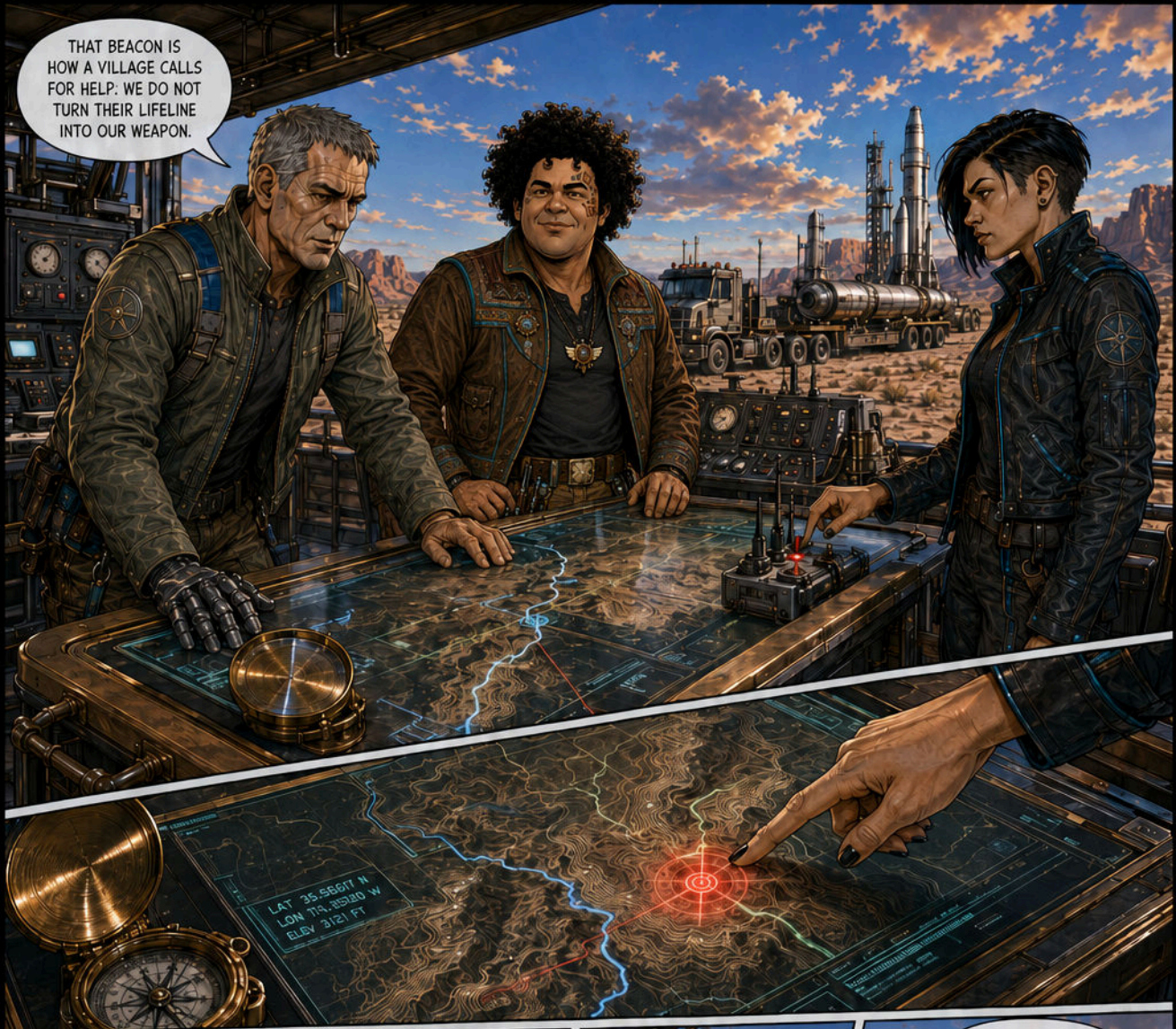


NOT
PEOPLE?



PEOPLE ARE WHY
MOVING MATTERS. THE
HORIZON JUST GIVES US
ROOM TO NOTICE.

THAT BEACON IS
HOW A VILLAGE CALLS
FOR HELP: WE DO NOT
TURN THEIR LIFELINE
INTO OUR WEAPON.



WHAT WOULD
YOU DO IF NOBODY
WERE CHASING US?



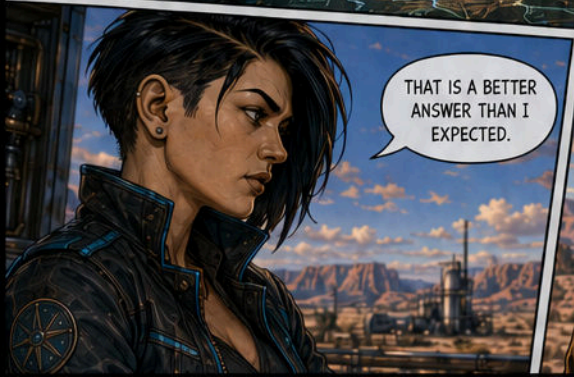
BUILD
SLOWER.



BUILD OPENLY. TEACH
EVERY SETTLEMENT TO
LAUNCH WITHOUT US.



THAT IS A BETTER
ANSWER THAN I
EXPECTED.

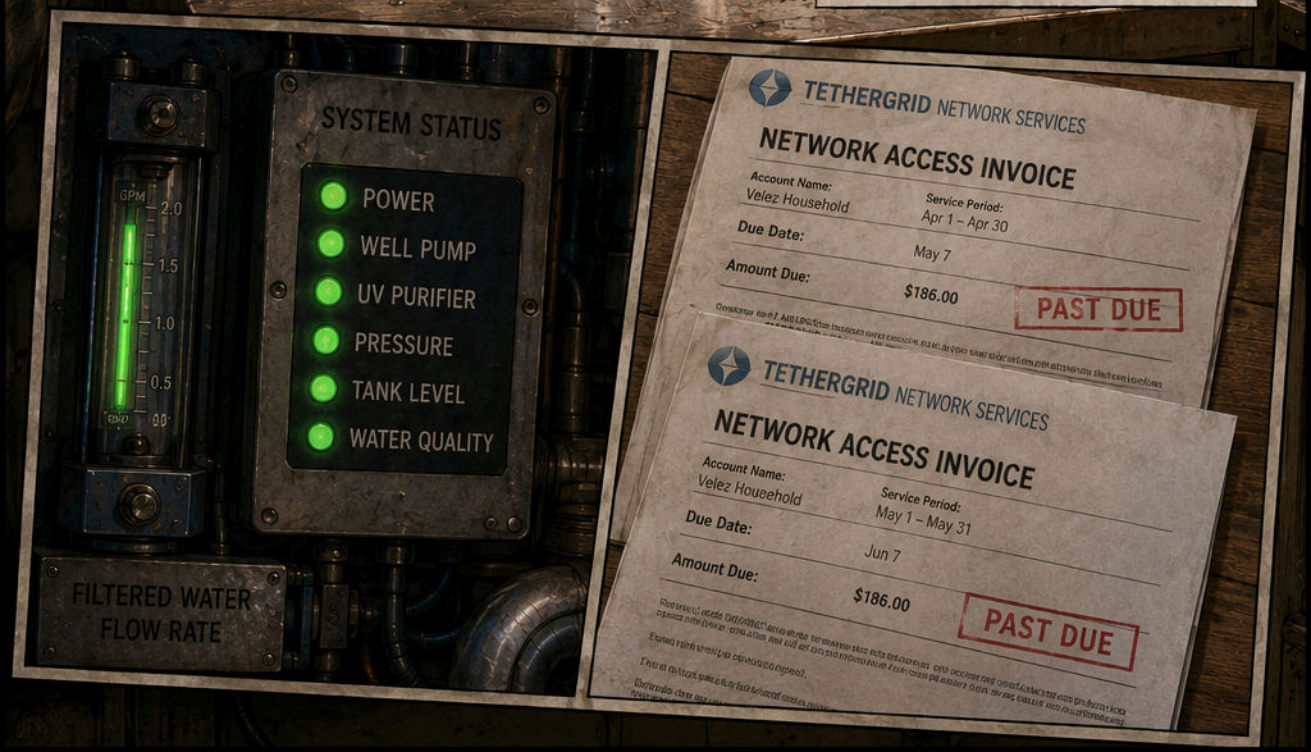


YOU DID ASK AN
OPEN-ENDED
QUESTION.

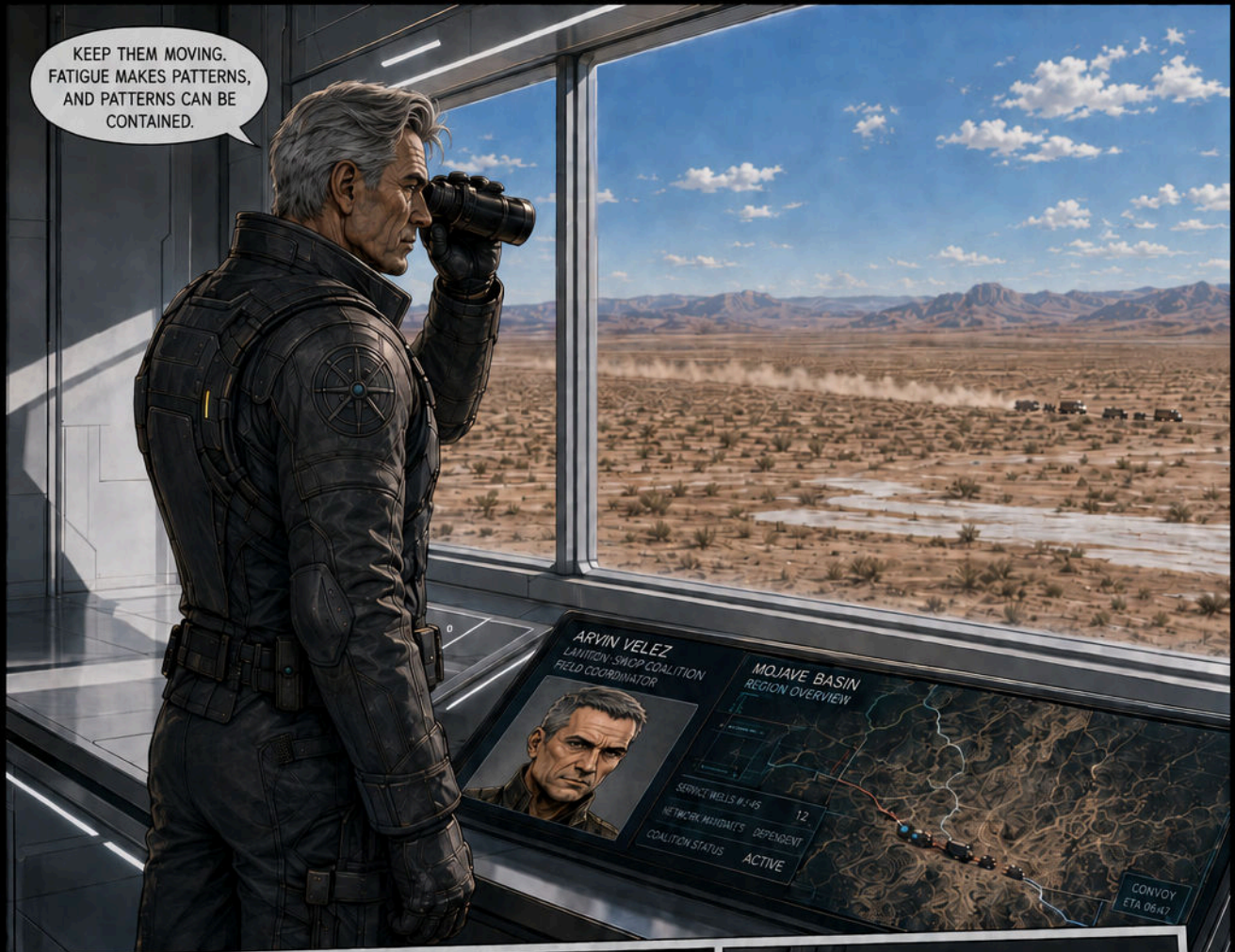




THE PURIFIER WORKS. THE WELL HAS WATER. TETHERGRID DISABLED BOTH AFTER THE VELEZ FAMILY MISSED TWO NETWORK PAYMENTS.



KEEP THEM MOVING.
FATIGUE MAKES PATTERNS,
AND PATTERNS CAN BE
CONTAINED.



ARVIN VELEZ
LAWTON SWEEP COALITION
FIELD COORDINATOR



MOJAVE BASIN
REGION OVERVIEW

SERVICE WELLS #1-45 12
NETWORK ANOMALIES DEPENDENT
COALITION STATUS ACTIVE

CONVOY
ETA 0647



WHAT DO YOU
THINK THEY BELIEVE
THEY ARE
PROTECTING?

NOT THE HARDWARE.
PEOPLE RARELY RISK
THIS MUCH FOR
HARDWARE.





WHEN DID YOU FIRST
DECIDE A LAUNCH WAS
WORTH GETTING CAUGHT
FOR?

IF THAT SPRING GOES,
THE VALVE STAYS OPEN. SHOW
ME THE BACKUP BEFORE EITHER
OF US TOUCHES IT.



I NEVER DECIDED
GETTING CAUGHT WAS
WORTHWHILE.

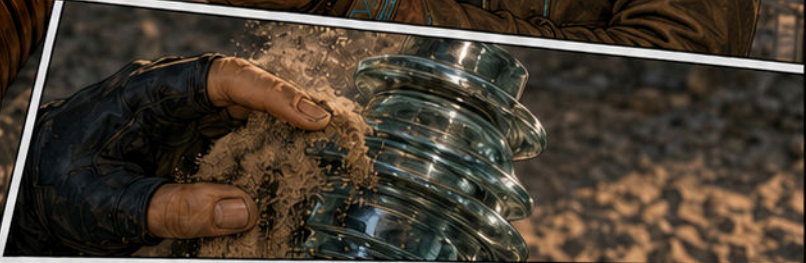
THAT SOUNDS
REASSURING.



I DECIDED THE PEOPLE
WAITING FOR THAT SIGNAL
WERE WORTH THE RISK. THEN
I ASKED ALL OF YOU TO DECIDE
FOR YOURSELVES.



THE FORBIDDEN FREQUENCY
REACHES THE BLACKOUT ZONE. I WILL
TELL ARVIN BEFORE WE INSTALL IT, BUT
I NEED TO KNOW IT WORKS FIRST.



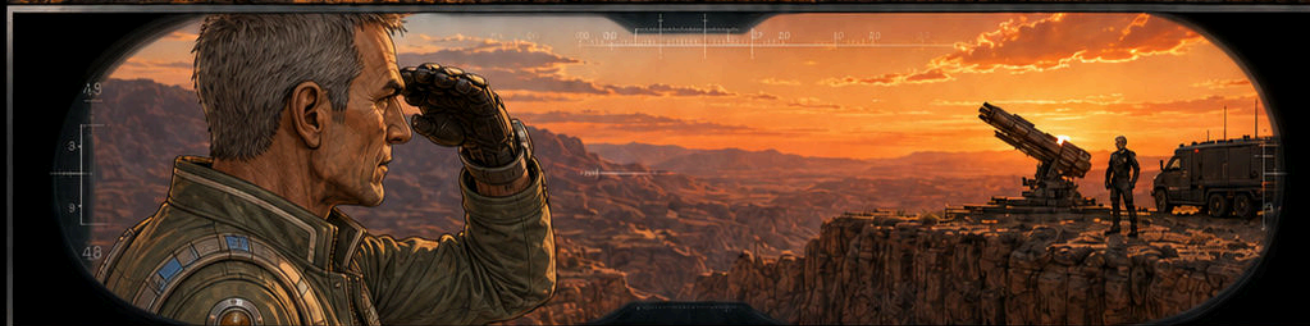
YOU KNOW
WHAT BAD PLANS
ARE GOOD FOR?



THEY
INCLUDE
US?



THEY EXPOSE
WHAT WE ARE
ACTUALLY PROTECTING.
THEN WE BUILD A
BETTER PLAN AROUND
THAT.

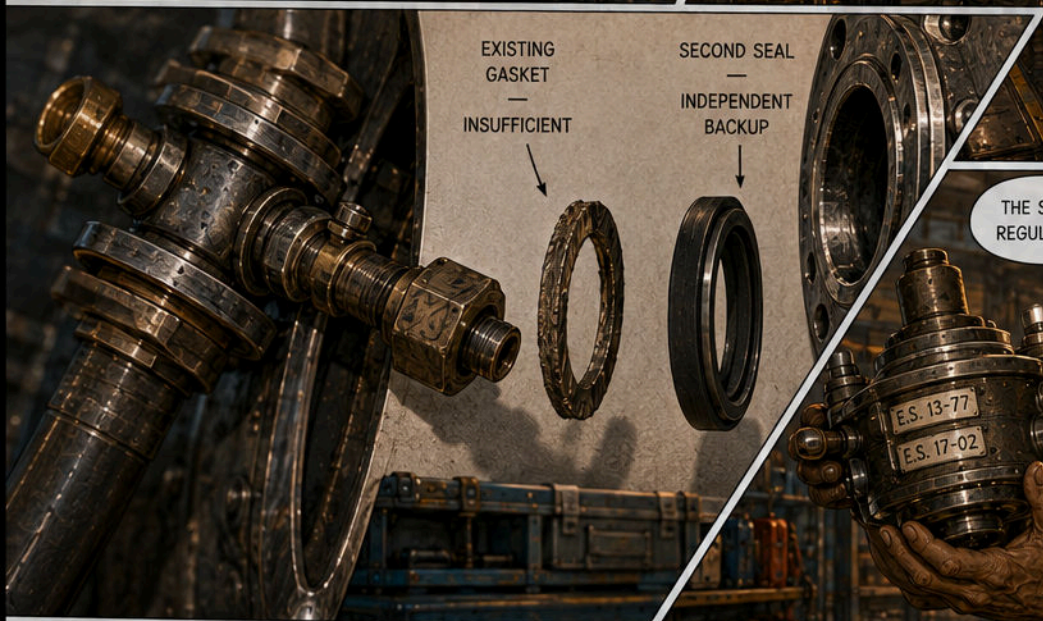




THIS GASKET FAILS, THE
PRESSURE RUNS AWAY. NOBODY
MOVES UNTIL WE GIVE IT A
SECOND SEAL.



IF WE HAVE TO
LEAVE ONE THING BEHIND,
WHAT IS IT?



EXISTING
GASKET
—
INSUFFICIENT

SECOND SEAL
—
INDEPENDENT
BACKUP



THE SPARE
REGULATOR.



NOT THE REGULATOR.
IT IS HEAVY BECAUSE IT
HAS SAVED US TWICE.

YOU ANSWERED
BEFORE I
FINISHED.

I KNOW. THAT IS
WHY I ANSWERED
BEFORE YOU
FINISHED.

YOUR TRAJECTORY
WORKS. THE QUESTION IS
WHO ABSORBS THE CONSEQUENCES
IF IT DOES NOT.



DO YOU THINK
CYRUS EVER GETS
TIRED?

OF US?
CONSTANTLY.



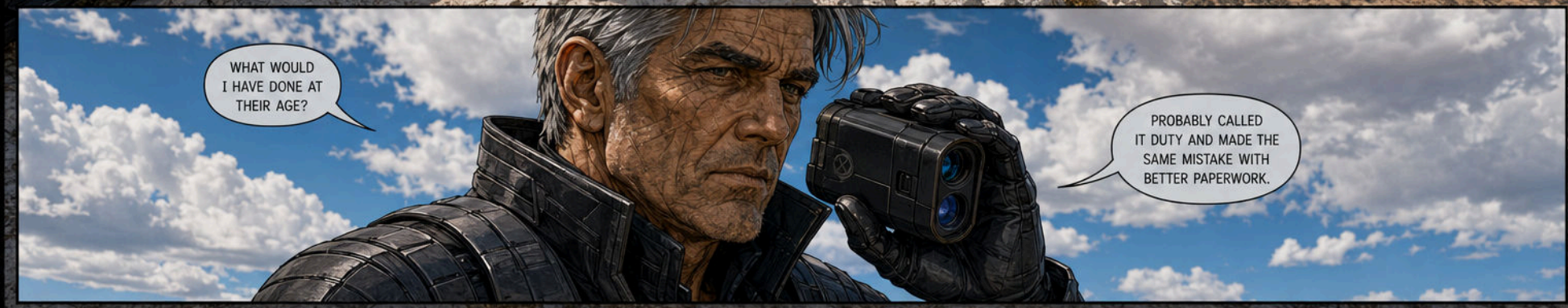
NO. JUST
TIRED.

THAT IS A MORE
INTERESTING
QUESTION.





TRACK THE
IGNITION SIGNATURE.
HOLD FIRE UNTIL I KNOW
WHERE THE DEBRIS
WOULD FALL.



WHAT WOULD
I HAVE DONE AT
THEIR AGE?

PROBABLY CALLED
IT DUTY AND MADE THE
SAME MISTAKE WITH
BETTER PAPERWORK.



SLOW POUR. IF THE
SEAL STARTS SINGING,
WE STOP BEFORE ANYBODY
LOSES A HAND.



